CERTRACE

Design system.

Structure, tokens, components, and page-level flow for the Certrace product ecosystem — compiled as a single reference for the exporter portal and every surface that shares its brand.

SOURCE OF TRUTH: DESIGN-TOKENS.JSON · DESIGN_SYSTEM.MD · COMPONENT_LIBRARY.MD · UI_PATTERN_LIBRARY.MD · BRAND_GUIDELINES.MD · LOGO_GUIDELINES.MD

CERTRACE.APP

JULY 2026

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A beautifully printed document that came alive.

For founders, marketers, and business stakeholders — no design background needed.

Everything sits on a warm paper-colored background — never pure white, never dark. Words are set in large, thin, elegant type. Small typewriter-style labels organize the page. Instead of photos or illustrations, the brand uses its own data: live tables, ticking counters, and little pulsing green dots that show the platform working in real time.

Color is used the way an auditor uses a highlighter: green means verified, amber means pending, red means overdue — and that's it. There is no "brand blue." The restraint *is* the brand.

Why it works

- **Matches the promise.** Certrace sells calm and order in a chaotic, high-stakes domain — the interface makes that promise believable before a word is read.
- **Shows, never tells.** Live supplier tables and audit trails act as proof, not testimonials.
- **Enterprise-credible.** Thin type, hairline lines, zero gimmicks read as infrastructure.
- **Cheap to maintain.** No photoshoots, no illustration budget — visuals are generated by code and type.

Three rules cover 90% of cases

- **Always the paper background** (#F5F4F0) — slides, posts, PDFs, pages.
- **Big thin headlines, tiny capital labels** — never bold titles, never colorful text.
- **Color only as status** — small green / amber / red dots and chips, nothing else.

If something feels "loud," it's off-brand. When in doubt, remove color, add whitespace.

Brand perception goal

A compliance director should think: *"serious infrastructure, already running, built by people who sweat details."* An investor should think: *"category-defining, enterprise-grade."* Never: loud, startup-y, gimmicky.

Calm infrastructure for a stressful domain.

The product handles regulatory deadlines, financial risk, and supply-chain chaos — so the interface does the opposite: quiet, ordered, warm, precise. The brand reads as an instrument, not an advertisement.

Brand attributes

ATTRIBUTE	HOW IT SHOWS UP IN THE UI
`Precise`	Monospace data surfaces, timestamped rows, hairline borders
`Calm`	Bone-white canvas, no saturated blocks, generous whitespace
`Trustworthy`	Flat elevation, restrained color, live / verifiable data
`Technical`	Pixel-art canvas icons, terminal-style activity logs
`Premium`	Light-weight display type, slow easing, blur-in motion
`Quietly optimistic`	Emerald used only for success and life signals

Design principles

Ink on bone

One warm off-white canvas, one near-black ink. Everything else is an opacity step. Color is information, never decoration.

Weight over size

Hierarchy through weight and opacity, not size alone. Headlines are large but light (300).

Borders, not shadows

Elevation via hairline borders and background shifts. Shadows are nearly invisible (≤8% black).

Motion is entrance

Things blur and rise into place with one signature easing curve. Nothing bounces, nothing spins.

Data is alive

Tables cycle, counters tick, dots pulse — proving the product works without a single testimonial.

Monochrome generative art

Canvas networks, pixel icons, CSS bar fields — drawn in code, never photography.

Visual philosophy — the interface should feel like a beautifully printed regulatory document that came alive: paper-colored ground, typographic restraint, mono details, small living indicators.
Tone — reading the page should feel like exhaling. Target arc for a compliance manager: *"This is serious software, it is already running, and it is going to be fine."*

The mark and the wordmark.



Two interlocking rounded "C" forms (read as a chain-of-custody / certification glyph) plus the CERTRACE wordmark, set in a Light-weight tracked-out sans matching the headline face — **not** the Courier Prime micro-label font used for eyebrows and tags. Treat the logo file as the source of truth; never redraw, retype, or approximate it by hand.

Which file to use

CONTEXT	FILE
Web navbar / footer, light bg	`horizontal.svg`
Dark #111 chapter-break slide	`horizontal-onDark.svg`
PowerPoint / Canva / Slides	`horizontal-ink@2400.png`
Favicon	`icon-ink-32/16.png`
App icon / social avatar	`icon-square-onBone-512.png`
Small UI chrome, square space	`icon.svg`

Clear space & minimum size

- Clear space on all sides ≥ height of the icon mark.
- Full lockup minimum: **96px** screen / **16mm** print — below that, drop to the icon mark alone.
- Icon mark alone minimum: **20px** (favicon-scale).
- Only on `#F5F4F0`, `#FFFFFF`, `#FAF9F7`, or `#111111`.

Never

- Stretch, skew, rotate, or recolor to any hue.
- Add drop shadow, glow, outline, or gradient.
- Retype the wordmark in Courier Prime or any other face.

No brand hue. Color is status only.

A warm neutral ground + ink ramp, with small functional status colors. There is no blue/green "brand" button — do not add one.

Ground

canvas	surface	surface-hover	surface-warm	surface-highlight
#F5F4F0	#FFFFFF	#FAFAF8	#FAF9F7	#F0EEE8

Ink ramp — text & lines (opacity steps of #111111)

Aa	Aa	Aa	Aa	Aa	Aa	Aa	Aa
100%	70%	55%	45% · body	40%	35% · caption	25–30%	20% · ghost

Status colors — used only at small scale (dots, chips, mono text)

STATUS	DOT	HEX	USAGE
success	#4ADE80	text #16A34A · chip #ECFDF5/#047857	Live / submitted dots, glow, progress fill
warning	#FACC15	text #B45309	Reminder / queued dots, gap flags
error	#F87171	text #DC2626 @70%	Overdue dots, "✗ Rejected" lines
info	#60A5FA	text #2563EB	In-progress dots, "→" log lines
muted	—	#9CA3AF / #6B7280	Mono comments / outputs

Contrast

- #111 on #F5F4F0 — 17.6:1, AAA. Headlines.
- black/55 ≈ 5.4:1, AA for body.
- black/45 ≈ 3.9:1 — large text only; use black/55+ for anything the user must read to operate the product.
- Status dots always paired with a text label — never color alone.

Rules

- Status colors never fill a card or button.
- Emerald is the only status color usable as decorative accent — and only at ≤20% alpha.
- No gradients as decoration; no colored buttons or rainbow charts.

Huge, thin headlines. Typewriter labels.

Aa Certificate.

IBM PLEX SANS · LIGHT 300 · DISPLAY / H1–H2

Body copy sits at 14px, black/45, leading-relaxed — the default paragraph voice across the product.

GEIST SANS · REGULAR · BODY & UI TEXT

SUP-2026-0417 · submitted · 04:12:09

GEIST MONO · CODE / LOG / DATA SURFACES

C E R T R A C E

COURIER PRIME · WORDMARK, EYEBROW LABELS, PLAN NAMES

Scale & hierarchy

LEVEL	PX	NOTES
Display / H1 hero	48 → 96	IBM Plex Sans, font-light, leading 1.0, manual line breaks
H2 section	36 → 48(60)	Rendered word-by-word blur-in, 2 lines max
H3 card title	18 → 24	Font-light, on white cards
Big numeral	36 → 80	Stats, cost bands, live counters
Body	14 / 1.625	black/45, default paragraph
Lead body	16	black/40, next to large headings
Label / eyebrow	11	tracking-widest, uppercase
Caption	12	black/35, tracking-wide, footnotes
Button	14	tracking-widest, uppercase

Letter-spacing tokens

tracking-tight (headings) · tracking-wide (captions/links) · tracking-widest (labels, buttons) · 0.16em (mono table headers) · 0.2em (footer column titles) · 0.25em (wordmark).

4px base unit. Sections breathe; cards stay dense.

Spacing tokens

TOKEN	VALUE	USAGE
space.section-y	py-32 (128px)	Every page section, top & bottom
space.section-x	24 / 48 / 80px	Section gutters (mobile → desktop)
space.heading-gap	mb-16 (64px)	Section header block → content
space.card-pad	p-8 (32px)	Card interiors; p-10 for banner cards
space.panel-pad	p-6 (24px)	Sub-panels, step buttons
space.card-gap	gap-3 (12px)	All card grids
space.col-gap	gap-8/12/20	2-column editorial layouts

Grid & containers

TOKEN	VALUE
container.section	max-w-6xl (1152px) — default for all sections
container.pricing	max-w-5xl (1024px)
container.narrow	max-w-3xl (768px) — navbar width, pull quotes
container.cta	max-w-2xl (672px) — centered CTA copy
breakpoints	sm 640 · md 768 · lg 1024 · xl 1280 (unused) · mobile-first

Radius system

sm · 8px | md · 12px · buttons, inputs | lg · 16px · cards, navbar | full · pills, dots

Rule of thumb: container = 16, control = 12, micro-element = 8, indicator = full. No other radii exist — never `rounded-3xl` or sharp corners.

Border + background first. Shadow second.

Shadow tokens (all black at ≤8% alpha)

shadow.nav shadow.float shadow.panel shadow.rest

Z-index layers

TOKEN	VALUE	LAYER
z.splash	100	Splash screen
z.nav	50	Navbar
z.content	30	Hero foreground text
z.overlay	10	Gradient/blur scrims, card inner content
z.base	0	Canvas / video backgrounds

Motion tokens

TOKEN	VALUE / ROLE
ease.signature	cubic-bezier(0.16,1,0.3,1) — every entrance (×15 in code)
duration.micro	200ms — hover color/border/arrow shifts
duration.enter	700ms — card rise-in, word blur-in
duration.hero	900–1000ms — hero element entrances
duration.cinematic	1300–2000ms — splash curtain, hero canvas scale
stagger	80ms between words / sibling cards

Signature effect — opacity 0→1, blur(8–16px)→0, translateY(12–28px)→0, on `ease.signature`. This is the brand's one recognizable move. Ambient loops stay slow (≥2s) and subtle (opacity ≤0.65). `prefers-reduced-motion` collapses everything to 0.01ms globally.

Buttons, badges, cards, forms.

Buttons

REQUEST A DEMO SEE HOW IT WORKS LEARN MORE →

Primary (dark #111, one per viewport-region max) · Secondary (outline, black/10) · Ghost (text link, arrow nudges 4px on hover). All: rounded-xl, tracking-widest uppercase, 200ms color-only transitions.

Badges, tags & status

THE PROBLEM LIVE SUPPORTED submitted queued overdue in progress

TagBadge = section eyebrow (one per header). Status chip = live/neutral state. Status dot + lowercase mono label = table rows — always paired with text, dots glow (success) or pulse (in-progress).

Cards

Feature card

Icon box → font-light title → black/45 body. p-8, min-h 200–240px.

Highlight card

bg #F0EEE8, border black/20. Max one per grid — featured plan, "After" panel.

AnimateCard is the universal container: rounded-2xl, border black/[0.07], white fill, scroll entrance (opacity+translateY, 700ms), mouse-glow overlay. Hover: border black/[0.15], bg #fafaf8.

Forms

your@company.com SUBMIT

White fill, border black/10, rounded-xl, placeholder black/25. Success state replaces the form with an emerald chip — never a redirect. Error (not yet built): border-red-400/60 + red helper text below, never a red fill.

Navigation, data, disclosure.

Navigation & footer

COMPONENT	SPEC
`Navbar`	Fixed, floating, max-w-3xl, glass pill (rgba canvas + 16px blur), shadow.nav. Wordmark left, 5 links, dark CTA pill right. Hamburger below md.
`Footer`	pt-16 pb-10, hairline top border. Brand block + 4 link columns (pixel-font titles, black/30). Legal row separated by black/[0.04].

Data display

COMPONENT	SPEC
`LiveSupplierTable`	Frame rounded-16, border 8% black. Mono header row (8px, 0.16em tracking). New row every 2.8s, progress bar emerald at 100%.
`CompletionCount`	Mono numeral clamp(3rem,6vw,5rem) weight 300; denominator at 25% black; drifts ±1 every 2.4s.
`Activity log`	Code-well, mono 12px/24px. Grammar: ✓ #16A34A success · ● #B45309 pending · → #2563EB progress · comment #9CA3AF.

Icons

PixelIcon — 40px canvas, animated, monochrome rgba fills, pixelated rendering. Variants: scatter, globe, funnel, leaf, steps, signal, people, shield, bars, doc. **Inline SVG —** 18px, stroke 1.5, inside a 40×40 rounded-xl bordered box. Never icon fonts or multicolor icons.

Disclosure & feedback

COMPONENT	SPEC
`FAQ accordion`	Hairline rows, plus-icon toggle (never chevron). maxHeight 0→240px + opacity, 400ms. One open at a time.
`Loading`	statusPulse on a dot + mono lowercase text ("processing…"). Skeletons: black/[0.04] rounded-xl pulsing. Never spinners.
`Empty state`	PixelIcon + black/45 line + one secondary button, centered in a dashed border-black/10 well.

One idea per section. Never reshuffle the order.

The marketing page-level sequence is itself a pattern. New marketing pages should subset this order.

SPLASH → HERO → MARQUEE → PROBLEM → WHY NOW → SOLUTION → PLATFORM →
HOW IT WORKS → LIVE PROOF → AUDIENCES → COVERAGE → PRICING → FAQ → FINAL CTA →
FOOTER

Section-level pattern recipes

PATTERN	RECIPE
`Hero`	h-screen, bottom-anchored, eyebrow → 3-line H1 → paragraph → 2 CTAs → 3-stat row, staggered blur-in
`Feature/problem grid`	Section header stack → card grid (gap-3), 3–4 AnimateCards, staggered 0/80/140ms
`Before/After`	2-col grid; left = white "BEFORE" card; right = highlight "AFTER" card, emerald rows win
`Sticky module stack`	3–4 cards pin at top:80+16i px, recede scale −0.04/+8px per depth
`Tabbed walkthrough`	lg:grid-cols-3 — step buttons left, glass panel + activity log right, auto-advance 3.6s
`Live proof`	lg:grid-cols-2 — CompletionCount + lead left, LiveSupplierTable + stat line right
`Pricing`	Centered header → 3 plan cards, middle = highlight + dark button
`Final CTA`	Ambient bar field, centered max-w-2xl, one email field + dark button, no redirect

Cross-pattern rules

- Every section: py-32 px-6/12/20 + border-t black/[0.06] + max-w-6xl mx-auto.
- Every section header: PixelIcon(40) → mt-4 TagBadge → mt-5 BlurHeading → optional body.
- Alternate rhythms (grid → editorial split → stack → grid) — two identical layouts never sit adjacent.
- Background art always dissolves into #F5F4F0 via progressive blur masks — never a hard edge.

Applying the system to the portal (app surfaces).

The exporter/importer/admin portals inherit every token on this page — same canvas, same ink ramp, same radius and motion rules — at a tighter, denser rhythm than the marketing site. No splash, no marquee; instant load with skeletons instead of blur-ins.

New dashboard screen — checklist

CANVAS BG #F5F4F0 → SIDEBAR (WHITE, HAIRLINE) → CONTENT CANVAS → HAIRLINE CARDS p-6 → MONO DATA GRAMMAR → STATUS DOTS

RULE	VALUE
Section rhythm	py-8/12 (vs. py-32 on marketing)
Card padding	p-6, gap-3
Sidebar	White, border-r black/[0.06]; content canvas stays #F5F4F0
Data tables	Follow the LiveSupplierTable recipe at 12–13px
Functional text contrast	black/55 minimum — black/45 is reserved for marketing prose

New-surface checklists (from FUTURE_DESIGN_INSTRUCTIONS.md)

- **New marketing page:** splash optional → hero (bottom-left) → alternate pattern types → final CTA → footer.
- **New dashboard screen:** canvas bg, white hairline cards, mono data grammar, status dots, no splash, no marquee.
- **New presentation/Canva asset:** follow the Brand Guidelines universal recipe (see Appendix).
- **Any AI agent:** copy exact class recipes from the Component Library; never invent values not in design-tokens.json.

Required. Prohibited. No exceptions.

For any future developer, designer, or AI agent building a new page, dashboard, or asset. Values live in design-tokens.json — when this and the code disagree, this is canonical.

REQUIRED

- Background of every surface: #F5F4F0. Cards: #FFFFFF (or #FAF9F7 in stacks). Exactly one #F0EEE8 highlight card per group.
- All text/lines derive from ink #111 at the documented opacity steps.
- Color = status only, at dot / chip / mono-text scale.
- Elevation = hairline border + background shift, shadows only from the token set.
- Decorative art = generative monochrome, dissolved via masked progressive blur.
- Entrances: blur-in with ease.signature, 700ms, 80ms stagger, IntersectionObserver-gated, run once.
- Visible :focus-visible ring (2px ink-40%) on every interactive element.

PROHIBITED

- Dark mode, pure-white or colored page backgrounds, decorative gradients.
- Colored buttons, colored card fills, colored headings.
- Stock photos, emoji in UI, drop-shadow "floating" cards, glassmorphism outside the navbar.
- New max-widths or breakpoints; two adjacent sections with identical grid layouts.
- Bold (≥600) headlines, italics, letter-spaced body text, ALL-CAPS headlines.
- Third-party UI kits without re-skinning; icon fonts; spinners; carousels.
- Bounce/spring/elastic easings; hover scale/lift on cards; parallax.

Accessibility requirements

- Semantic landmarks, one h1, ordered headings; aria-label on icon-only controls; aria-hidden on decorative canvas/marquee.
- Status conveyed by text + color, never color alone. Forms: real labels, errors as text.
- Functional text contrast ≥4.5:1 (black/55+); black/45 reserved for marketing prose.

Do's, don'ts, and where everything lives.

DO

- Use #F5F4F0 as the background of everything — slides, posts, one-pagers.
- Set headlines big and Light (300). Let whitespace do the talking.
- Use UPPERCASE Courier Prime for small labels and the wordmark.
- Keep color for status only — small dots, chips, or text.
- Round corners: 16px cards/containers, 12px buttons, full pills.
- Show real-looking data instead of abstract illustrations.

DON'T

- No pure white or dark-mode backgrounds. No gradients as decoration.
- No bold/black headline weights, no italics, no ALL-CAPS headlines.
- No saturated color fills or colored buttons — the only dark fill is #111.
- No stock photography, emoji, drop shadows, or bouncy animations.
- More than one highlighted (#F0EEE8) card per group.

The universal marketing-asset recipe

1. Fill the background #F5F4F0.
2. Top-left: small UPPERCASE Courier Prime eyebrow at 40% ink.
3. One big IBM Plex Sans Light headline, 2 lines max, sentence case, period at the end.
4. One short supporting line at 45% ink.
5. One element of "life": a stat numeral, a tiny green dot + label, or a small data table mock.
6. Bottom: wordmark CERTRACE in Courier Prime, wide-tracked, 50% ink.
7. Optional: one dark #111 rounded (12px) button-style CTA chip.

Where everything lives

NEED	FILE
Full technical reference	`DESIGN_SYSTEM.md`
Reusable components	`COMPONENT_LIBRARY.md`
Page section recipes	`UI_PATTERN_LIBRARY.md`
Rules for non-designers	`BRAND_GUIDELINES.md`
Rules for future builders & AI	`FUTURE_DESIGN_INSTRUCTIONS.md`
One-file AI brief	`DESIGN_SYSTEM_AI_CONTEXT.md`
Machine-readable values	`design-tokens.json`
Logo files & usage rules	`LOGO_GUIDELINES.md` · `assets/logo/`